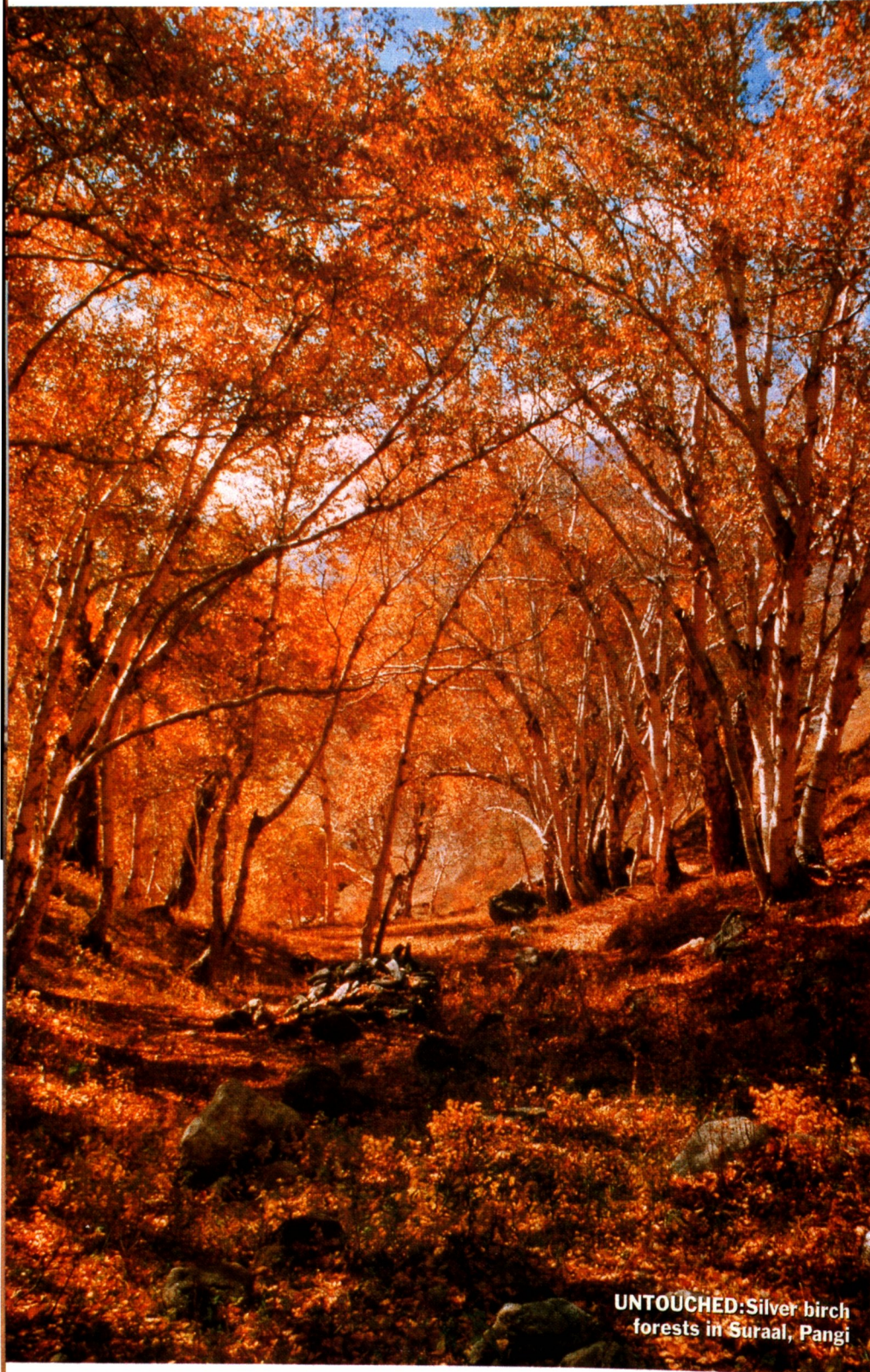


WHERE ANGELS TREAD



PLACE TO FALL OFF THE MAP PANGI VALLEY, HIMACHAL PRADESH



UNTOUCHED: Silver birch forests in Suraal, Pangi

Pangi valley has long been the ground that separates the serious trekker from the tourist. Situated on the north-western extreme of Himachal Pradesh, few know of its whereabouts. Until the late '90s, the only access to this remote region—where prisoners of the erstwhile Chamba state were sent according to folklore—was through arduous treks over high mountain routes like the Sach (14,478 feet) or the Cheni pass (14,382 feet). Even today, Pangi's only link is through a road from the Lahaul valley, which is so precarious at some stretches that driving is elevated to the level of the miraculous. At 8,000 feet, Pangi is land-locked between the Pir Panjal and the Zaskar ranges. Not exactly a valley, the region is a deep gorge formed by the

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emerald green Chandra-bhaga (Chenab) river snaking through it. The gorge is connected to four smaller valleys—Suraal, Saichu, Kumar and Parmar—all of which stem from the Zaskar range. Within these sub-valleys is the true essence of the journey—the gold-embalmed groves of silver birch (*bhojpatra*) forests, springs of glistening mica water, eyes that look back without guile or suspicion, and a culture imbued with its own pristine flavour. A world for few to reach—and still fewer to discover.

by Bandeeep Singh

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